

SESSION SEVEN: THE TURNING AWAY

The Qilvayas Symphony

An adventure for 4–6 characters of 6th level – the price of the Seal, the rooms beneath the rooms, and the faces that would not look

OVERVIEW

The party opens the Second Seal and descends into the Undercourt's deepest reach: three chambers of a sacred site built for a ceremony that two people were supposed to walk out of. This is not a dungeon crawl. It is an approach, and each chamber strips something away rather than throwing something at them — the practical wreckage of preparation, a corridor that makes them honest, and finally the Witness Hall, where several hundred people watched the empire's founding and chose to see nothing. The session ends on the frieze and what it means, with the party holding proof that could end houses.

Designed for a five-hour core. Pacing budget: the price of the Seal (40 minutes); the Threshold Arch and the Vesting Room, run as the four-solution puzzle it is (65 minutes); the Long Approach in its four phases (60 minutes); the Witness Hall (90 minutes, including the Turned); the frieze, the effaced benches, and the implications (45 minutes). Optional content adds roughly 90 minutes. Combat is deliberately sparse — one encounter, and it is a puzzle wearing a fight's clothes. Milestone: the party reaches 7th level at the session's close.

Where the keyed areas fit. C1 through C7 are the same session at higher resolution, and the budget above already carries them: C1 is two minutes and a hesitation, C2 and C3 are the sixty-five, C4 and C5 are the Long Approach's sixty, C6 is the ninety, and C7 is the last image before the session ends. Nothing is added on top. The Long Approach is the one block that must not be compressed — it has no combat, no checks that matter, and it is the best hour in the campaign.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

The founding was witnessed. Several hundred people stood in the Witness Hall to see Zhuvedus and Threnvos swear the covenant that would make an empire — and when Zhuvedus broke it, the assembly turned away in unison. In this world's metaphysics that is not cowardice; it is mechanism. Oaths bind because they are witnessed (Tarnovari stone-oaths, marriage before a Church witness, Norr's landholders swearing before the assembled hall). When the assembly refused to see, they unwitnessed the covenant — and the unbinding is what made the betrayal possible rather than merely unpunished. Zhuvedus struck the blow. The witnesses made it a founding.

Two consequences run the rest of the campaign. First: the shadow does not feed only on broken oaths, it feeds on the silence around them — every institutional look-away in the empire is the same act as the Hall, which is why the Brekelands' ghoul density tracks unburied parley-breaches and not banditry. Second: witnessing starves it, and the Vigil — watched, lit, never left alone — is the counter-rite. The

Vigil is penance. It was instituted by the witnesses or their children as an apology none of their descendants remember making, and it is the one practice that survives unchanged across every schism in the empire. The party already performed it correctly at Redwatch, for men they killed, for no reward, and nobody told them.

And the Church has been carrying the proof of it in plain sight for four hundred years. There is a saint of witnesses in the Canon: Marek the Witness, who saw a lord break a parley-oath, was invited to say he had seen nothing, said what he saw, and was executed for it. His feast falls in Threshold, the liminal month when old oaths are renewed and old debts settled. His icon is an open eye above a closed mouth, and the standard explanation — that testimony given once needs no second telling — is the wrong answer, and the right one is written down nowhere. He is the saint of this campaign's central mechanism and no theologian in the empire has noticed. If a character prays to Marek in the Witness Hall, let it work, and let absolutely nothing announce that it did.

Third, and the piece that reframes the throne: the Golden Tablets were composed by the witnesses. The empire's sacred founding law is the self-exoneration document of the people who looked away — which is precisely what Nyreeza meant by "the wound predates the Wall. The Tablets were written over it." The law was the cover-up, written first. Qilvayas is rewriting the Tablets right now, and a legal code that makes oaths enforceable, witnessed, and recorded is, in this metaphysics, a literal starvation regimen against the thing beneath his city. He built the only real weapon by institutional instinct, without any idea what he was doing. His Daily Draw — the one habit his clerks find inefficient — is him personally witnessing one citizen a day. It is the most important thing he does.

The scouring is a second crime and the same crime. Roughly two hundred years ago, as the fracture began, Emperor Vaskaren the Restorer went looking for why his empire was failing, found the Witness Hall, and had it methodically erased by masons working for weeks — an act of un-witnessing performed by the one family the founding had made. His restoration failed. Qilvayas is the second restorer of that line and does not know whether he is repeating the pattern or breaking it. Vaskaren's order survives in the dynastic archive; it is how Empress Nyreeza found the way down, and it is what waits, unopened, in her sealed dispatch case.

SCENE 1: THE PRICE OF THE SEAL

The Seal has not changed since you left it. Twenty feet of black stone furred white in air that has never known winter, the carvings in an alphabet your educations do not contain, and at its foot the word a dead Empress scratched when her cipher stopped being enough. The cold is a pressure now, not a temperature. And behind the stone, slower than you remember it, something breathes.

The Seal is not a puzzle and not a check. It is a door built to be opened from the ceremonial side by two people speaking together — and there is one party, on the wrong side, two thousand years late. What opens it is an oath: a real one, spoken aloud by a player character in the place where sworn words carry, and meant. Not a password, not a formula. An actual commitment the campaign will hold them to.

- **Running it:** Tell the players plainly that the door responds to sworn words. Do not tell them what to say. Let the table sit in the silence; it will be uncomfortable, and it should be. Whatever a character finally says, write it down verbatim. That promise is now load-bearing and the thing below heard it.
- **Weight, not wording:** Any sincere oath opens the Seal. A joke, a hedge, or a deliberately trivial vow does nothing at all — the stone simply does not respond, and the failure is not a mechanic to be gamed but a mirror. A character who tries to cheat the door and then swears honestly gets in on the honest attempt.
- **What it costs:** The oath is real. Record it in the Branch Ledger. The campaign should honor it — keeping it earns nothing mechanical, but breaking it, later, in front of the thing that heard it, is the single worst thing anyone in this party can do.

When the oath is spoken, the Seal does not grind or shudder. The frost sublimates off its face in one breath, the carvings run with condensation like a fever breaking, and it opens inward on a stair, and the smell comes up.

SCENE 2: THE VESTING ROOM

You expected the grave. What you get is cedar smoke and resin — faint, cold, two thousand years stale, and unmistakably the smell of a rite: the incense of an oath-swearing, the scent of every formal room any of you have ever stood in. Your noses say temple. Your noses say celebration. Everything else says otherwise. The chamber is small and practical: stone benches, a dry basin, iron pegs along one wall. Preparation happened here. Two sets of everything — and one set is still laid out, folded, on the bench where it was left.

The room where the two of them prepared, and the room where the party understands what kind of place this is. The unused ceremonial vestments are the module's quietest artifact: someone folded them, set them out, and nobody ever put them on. They are undecayed — the cold has kept

them — and they are the correct size for a Drow of ordinary build.

NYREEZA'S CAMP

In the corner, three years old and immediately recognizable: a bedroll, the ash of a small fire, a stub of surveyor's chalk, and a stack of notes weighted under a stone. She camped here. For some length of time — the notes suggest a week, perhaps more — an Empress of Zhuvendus sat alone in this room and worked. Give this discovery room to land; the party has been following her for six sessions and this is the first place she stayed.

- **The notes (readable, her cipher, and the party has the key):** Measurements. Sketches of the paired architecture with the second figure's absence marked and re-marked. A list of nine names in the old orthography, seven crossed out. And one page that is not survey work at all: a draft of a letter to her son, begun four times and abandoned four times, the longest attempt reaching eleven words. "Qilvayas — there is a thing under our house that we" and then nothing.
- **The archive citation:** One marginal note references a dynastic archive shelf-mark, not a public one. If the party pursues it later, it leads to Vaskaren's scouring order — and to the fact that Nyreeza read it before she came down. She knew what she was looking for.
- **What is not here:** A body. No blood, no struggle, no remains. She left this room walking. (Her fate remains open by design — do not resolve it here or anywhere else without deciding to.)

SCENE 3: THE LONG APPROACH

The corridor beyond is built for a crowd: forty feet wide, colonnaded, a processional way meant to carry two columns of witnesses walking in together. Your footsteps do not echo. Words go flat and short, swallowed within a pace or two, and you find yourselves standing closer than you meant to. The cold sharpens. It is not the cold of winter or of stone. Every one of you knows this cold from somewhere else: the corridor outside a sickroom, the moment before bad news, the specific chill of a place where something has just been lost. Your hands stay warm. Your chest aches.

Two systems govern this corridor, and neither is a trap in the mechanical sense.

SWORN WORDS CARRY

Ordinary speech dies within a few feet. Sworn language does not. An oath, a vow, a promise — even a casual "I swear" — rings down the full length of the corridor with perfect clarity and keeps ringing a half-second longer than it should. The party will discover this by accident, almost certainly from someone saying something they did not mean formally. Do not explain it. Let them work it out, and let them start watching their language. A table that begins self-censoring their characters' speech out of superstition has arrived exactly where this dungeon wants them.

THE MEMORY PRESSURE

The corridor does not attack. It makes people honest. As the party advances, each character surfaces an unkept promise of their own — not a vision, not an illusion, not a save: plain intrusive memory, the specific and personal kind that arrives unbidden at three in the morning. Ask each player, once, quietly, in whatever order feels right: “What does your character remember that they’d rather not?”

- **Handling the answers:** Whatever they say becomes canon. Record it. This is the single most valuable thing the module produces — six sessions of established characters, and now the DM holds each one’s worst unfinished business, volunteered by the player. It will feed personal arcs for the rest of the campaign.
- **If a player declines:** Let them. “Your character keeps it down” is a legitimate answer and a characterful one. Do not push; the corridor is patient and so is the campaign.
- **Shadows:** Somewhere along the corridor, an observant character (passive Perception 15, or anyone who thinks to check) notices that shadows fall toward the deep places rather than away from the light. Let the player who spots it be the one to say it aloud.

SCENE 4: THE WITNESS HALL

The corridor opens and the ceiling goes away. A hall the size of a cathedral, tiered on all four sides — stone benches rising in ranks, hundreds upon hundreds of places, each one worn in the particular way stone wears when someone has stood on it a long time. This room held an audience. At the center, below the tiers, a floor of pale inlaid stone waits for a ceremony. And every surface that once bore a face or a name has been scoured smooth — not smashed, not defaced in rage: ground down, methodically, by people who took their time and were paid for the work.

The Hall is the session’s destination and the campaign’s hinge. Run the discovery in three movements, and do not rush any of them.

FIRST MOVEMENT — THE SCALE OF IT

Let the party simply understand the room. A DC 14 Intelligence (Investigation) or any Seal-house education establishes the seating capacity at several hundred; the wear patterns establish they stood rather than sat, and stood for a long time. Whatever happened here was public, formal, and attended. The empire’s official account of the founding — a hero, a wilderness, a divine mandate — contains no mention of an audience at all.

SECOND MOVEMENT — THE TURNED

When the party moves onto the ceremonial floor, they wake. See the stat block. The Turned are what remains of witnesses who died having never looked back — faceless, not by mutilation but by absence, their heads permanently averted from whatever they are nearest to. They do not approach. They do not attack anyone who is looking at them. They move, and strike, only when unobserved.

- **The encounter is a puzzle wearing a fight’s clothes.** Killing them is possible and unsatisfying and the room

gets colder for it. The solution is to look at them — specifically, for a character to hold their gaze on one and not stop, and say what they see. A Turned that is witnessed — truly attended to, named aloud as a person who was here and did nothing — stops. It turns. It has no face to show, but it turns, and then it is gone, and the cold in that part of the room eases. This is the party’s first practical proof that witnessing is the counter-rite, and they will not have been told.

- **Scaling:** Four characters: 4 Turned. Five: 5. Six: 6, and one of them is a Turned Elder (as Turned, but 68 hp and its Unobserved Strike deals an extra 1d8). If the party solves the witnessing trick early, do not punish the discovery by adding more — let them clear the room fast and feel clever. The scene’s payload is the frieze, not the fight.

THIRD MOVEMENT — THE FRIEZE

The scouring is thorough. It is thorough on the floor, on the plinths, on every tier your lantern reaches — and then, on the highest tier of the eastern gallery, forty feet up where the light barely goes and a man on a scaffold worked alone at the end of a long day, it stops. Two spans of frieze survive. Faces. Dozens of them, carved with the particularity of portraiture — this nose, this jaw, this braid, this house-sigil worked into a collar. They are not fleeing. They are not screaming. Every single face is turned away, deliberately, in the same instant, with the composure of people who have decided together and without a word to see nothing at all.

Give the table the silence. Then let them work out what they are looking at, and do not help them. The pieces are all present: an audience, a founding, a betrayal, and several hundred people who chose not to witness it. If nobody arrives at it, that is fine — the rubbing goes in their pack and the realization can land in Session Eight, or at Vaelindra’s table, or three sessions later at the worst possible moment.

- **The rubbing:** Taking one is the obvious move and the party has the technique (Session Three). It is the only record of the founding’s true shape above ground, and the faces are identifiable — house-sigils, distinctive features, enough that a Crownlands noble could recognize an ancestor. Several of those houses currently hold seats at Qilvayas’s court.
- **The trap the Hall sets:** The party now holds proof that delegitimizes the throne mid-restoration, hands Orlath a weapon, vindicates Tarnovar, and probably breaks the Church. Keeping it quiet is safer for everyone — and keeping it quiet makes them the newest witnesses to turn away. The room has just finished teaching them what that costs. Do not state this. They will feel it, and the ones who do not will feel it later.
- **Evidence of the scourers:** DC 15 Investigation on the floor beneath the surviving frieze: two centuries of dust, and under it, a rust-stain the shape of a scaffold foot, and a single broken mason’s chisel of imperial make. Someone was paid to do this. The order has a name on it, and the name is in an archive the party can eventually reach.

End the session in the Hall, under the faces. The way onward — a low arch on the western side, unscoured because nothing there bore a name — is visible, and the breathing comes from it, and it is slower than it was. Milestone: 7th level.

THE UNDERCOURT, KEYED

Sessions Seven and Eight take place in one continuous structure, and it is the oldest built thing in the world. Twelve areas across both sessions — seven here, five in Session Eight. Key it, draw it, and let the players map it, because the Undercourt is the only dungeon in this campaign the party will never be able to come back to.

The shape of it. Not a dungeon in the usual sense: a single ceremonial axis, descending, with rooms opening off it in the order a procession would have needed them. Vesting first, then approach, then witness, then rite. It was built for one event and it has been waiting to be used properly ever since. Nothing here is a corridor to somewhere else; every space is a stage in a ceremony, and the party is walking the ceremony in order without knowing the order.

On light and time. Bring both. The Undercourt has no natural light, no water, and no exit but the way in. State the party's oil and torch supply at the top of Session Seven, track it honestly, and let a party that has been careless find out about it at the worst moment — this is the one place in the campaign where resource management is a horror device rather than an accounting chore.

C1. The Threshold Arch. Where the black stone stops being a wall and becomes an entrance. Twelve feet, unornamented, and cut with such precision that the joints will not take a knife. The Second Seal's dead wardline runs across the floor here as a groove filled with a gray metal nobody can identify. Crossing it is a step, and everyone will hesitate.

C2. The Vesting Room. Stone benches, ten niches, and the ceremonial dress of a rite that was never finished — two full sets, laid out, unworn. Nyreeza's camp is here: a bedroll, a lamp, a folded coat, a working table with rubbings pinned to it, and a discipline about the arrangement that will tell the party more about her than any document. Session Seven's first real room and its most human.

C3. The Instrument Store. Off the Vesting Room. Racks for tools of a rite: a broken chisel with a masons' guild stamp still in use today, a set of copper bowls, and eleven pegs, three of them empty. Nobody will ever learn what hung on the three empty pegs and the DM should never decide.

C4. The Long Approach. Three hundred feet, descending at a constant grade, proportioned for a procession of hundreds and walked by four to six people. The memory pressure lives here — see the phased set piece below. There is nothing to fight in the Long Approach. It is the hardest room in the module.

C5. The Standing Water. A hundred feet in, the Approach's floor dips and holds an inch of water that has been there for two thousand years and is perfectly clear. It reflects. What it reflects is not always what is standing over it, and the module never explains this, and a party that stops to investigate loses ten minutes and gains nothing but the memory.

C6. The Witness Hall. Where Session Seven ends. Tiered stone benches on four sides of a floor, seating for perhaps four hundred, and every seat cut with a name that has been deliberately effaced — not weathered, effaced, with a tool, by somebody who went round all four hundred. See the scene text.

C7. The Vestibule of the Rite. Between the Witness Hall and the Rite Floor. A short antechamber with a single stone basin, dry, and above it the only carving in the Undercourt that is decorative rather than functional: two figures, facing, one of them chiselled out. Session Seven ends before this room or at its threshold, depending on the table's pace.

THE LONG APPROACH (SET PIECE, IN PHASES)

Three hundred feet of descending corridor with nothing in it, run in four phases over roughly an hour, with a decision at every transition. This is the module's centrepiece and it contains no combat whatsoever. Do not add any.

Phase One — The First Hundred Feet (10 minutes).

Nothing happens. Describe the grade, the proportions, the way the party's light does not reach the ceiling. Let them get comfortable and let them start talking about something else. The decision at the transition: marching order, and whether they rope together, and whether anyone says out loud that this is fine. Note who says it.

Phase Two — The Pressure Begins (15 minutes). Each character begins to remember something they have not thought about in years, vividly, at the wrong moment. Not visions and not an attack: memory, unbidden and specific. Go around the table and ask each player what their character suddenly remembers, and take whatever they give you. The decision: does the party stop and talk about it, or push on and pretend? Both are correct. A party that stops loses twenty minutes of oil and gains something they will need in Session Eight.

Phase Three — The Selection (20 minutes). The memories stop being random. Each character now remembers, specifically and in order, a promise they made and did not keep. Small ones. A DC 13 Wisdom saving throw resists the intensity, not the content — nobody gets to not remember. The decision, and it is the real one: does anyone say theirs out loud? Nothing mechanical rewards it. Everything about Session Eight is easier for a party who did.

Phase Four — The Last Fifty Feet (15 minutes). The pressure stops, abruptly, as though something lost interest or got what it wanted. The relief is enormous and it should be played as relief. The decision at the transition into the Witness Hall: after what just happened, does the party still walk in together? Ask them to state marching order again. The answer will be different from Phase One and nobody will comment on it.

DM Only: the Approach is not attacking them and it is not the shadow. It is the building doing what it was built to do: a processional route designed to bring celebrants to the Rite Floor already reckoning with their own broken words, because that was the price of admission to the thing that happened here. It is a liturgy, still running, with no congregation. Nothing in the corridor wants anything. That is the most frightening available reading and it is the true one.

THE VESTING ROOM

(PUZZLE)

Nyreeza's camp is a puzzle in the shape of a room, and it is solved by inference rather than by checks. Everything in C2 is evidence about a person, and the question the room asks is: what was she doing, and did she leave, or did she go on?

Ten niches, two sets of ceremonial dress, laid out and never worn. Between them, three years of somebody's residence: a bedroll rolled tight in the way a soldier rolls one, a lamp with the wick trimmed and no oil, a coat folded on a bench, a working table with charcoal rubbings pinned flat and weighted at the corners with four identical stones. The rubbings are of the Approach's walls. Along one edge of the table, a line of tally-marks — a great many of them — and at the end of the line, no mark, just the space where the next one would go.

Solution one — the coat. It is folded, not dropped. Nobody who fled folded their coat. DC 12 Wisdom (Insight) for a character to articulate this; most players get there without a roll, and should be allowed to.

Solution two — the tallies. Count them. They are days, and the count is short of three years by a considerable margin — she stopped marking long before three years had passed, which means either she left, or she stopped caring about days. DC 13 Intelligence (Investigation) to get an accurate count; the number itself should be given as a number and its meaning withheld.

Solution three — the lamp. The wick is trimmed and there is no oil. A person preparing to leave does not trim a wick. A person preparing to go further with no intention of coming back to this room might. This is the reading that hurts and it is entirely legitimate.

Solution four — the stones. Four identical stones weighting the rubbings, and they are from the Long Approach's standing water, and there are four of them because the rubbings are of four walls, and a person who went and fetched four matching stones for a table she was going to abandon was not abandoning it. She meant to come back to this table.

What the room does not answer. Whether she did. Every solution above tells the party something about her intentions and none of them tells them her fate, and the module must not resolve it. A party that leaves the Vesting Room certain of what happened to the Empress has been given something this campaign does not have.

HAZARDS OF THE UNDERCOURT

Scarred Ground (everywhere below C1). The Undercourt is Scarred thin-written ground, the strongest degree in the setting. Wards will not anchor. Ritual casting fails, not sometimes but always. Long rests restore half the usual Hit Dice and no expended spell slots above 3rd level. Divination returns grief. State all of this to the players at C1, plainly, in the DM's own voice, and then never soften it.

The Cold. Not damage. A creature that spends more than an hour below C1 without a heat source has disadvantage on Constitution saving throws until it warms up. A fire can be lit and there is nothing here to burn, which is a supply problem the party must have solved above ground or must now solve badly.

The Standing Water (C5). No mechanics. If a player asks what their character sees in the reflection, the honest answer is: describe them a half-second late. Do it once. Do not do it twice and do not explain it, ever.

The Effaced Benches (C6). A character who examines the effacement closely can determine, DC 14 Intelligence (Investigation), that it was done from one end to the other in a single working, by one hand, with a chisel — the same gauge as the broken chisel in C3. Somebody sat in this hall, alone, and went along four hundred names, and stopped when the chisel broke, and the last forty names are still legible. They should be read aloud.

HANDOUT — SESSION SEVEN

FROM THE WORKING TABLE (C2)

(In a small, fast, educated hand, on the back of a rubbing:) Third attempt at the west wall. The marks are not writing. I have been wrong about this for a year and I am writing it down so that I stop. They are a count. Something down here was counting, and it stopped counting, and the stopping is the only event recorded in this entire building. — Below, in the same hand, later, and much less carefully: it is not a building. it is a promise that somebody made in stone because stone holds what air forgets. I have to go down.

Note for the DM: hand this over when the party searches the table. The last four words are the session's engine and they should be in the players' hands, in ink, for the whole of Session Eight.

OPTIONAL CONTENT (BEYOND THE FIVE-HOUR CORE)

The Ninth Name (~40 minutes, in the Vesting Room): Nyreeza's list of nine names in old orthography, seven crossed out, is a genuine puzzle: they are the nine great houses that stood in the front rank of the Hall. Seven are extinct. Two are not. A party that works this out — Vell can help, so can a good History check against the surviving frieze sigils — learns which two families at court descend directly from the front row, and the DM gains a pair of NPCs with two thousand years of buried motive. (Which houses is the DM's call; choosing an existing court figure is recommended and delicious.)

The Chisel's Maker (~30 minutes): The broken chisel bears a maker's stamp — a masons' guild mark still in use in Aenodira, because the guild is dwarven and dwarven guilds do not change their marks. The current guildmaster can date

it within a decade and will, if approached respectfully, consult the guild's own work-ledgers: two centuries back, a large commission, paid from the imperial purse, its purpose left blank. Dwarven record-keeping outlasts imperial cover-ups, and the guild has never once been asked about it.

What the Vestments Fit (~20 minutes): A character who thinks to compare the unused ceremonial vestments against themselves learns they are cut for a Drow of ordinary build. In an empire where the Founder's Blood is nearly extinct and the dynasty is its last house, that is a fact with a very short list of implications — and the party may reach the correct one two sessions before anyone tells them the second champion's name.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

Record outcomes in the Branch Ledger.

- **The Seal-oath, and who swore it:** The character who opened the door is now personally bound in the campaign's central mechanism, and the thing below heard them. Note the exact words. If that character is ever pressured to break that specific promise — and the campaign should eventually arrange it — that is a session-defining crisis, not a moral quandary.
- **The memory pressure answers:** Each character's volunteered unkept promise is now canon and is the seed of their personal arc. Players who declined keep the ambiguity; do not force it later, but the corridor remembers, and so does the DM.
- **The Turned — witnessed vs. destroyed:** Witnessed: the party has practiced the counter-rite without being taught it, and Session Eight's Vigil will come to them intuitively. Destroyed: the Vigil is harder, the room is colder, and the DM should let the party notice — in Session Eight — that the ones they killed are still here, still turned, still waiting to be seen.
- **The rubbing, taken or left:** Taken: the party carries a political bomb, and every faction that learns of it wants it. Left: the Hall stays a secret they merely know, which is safer and quietly corrosive — and the DM should note who argued for leaving it.
- **Told or untold:** Whether the party ever shows the rubbing to Shen, Vaelindra, Vell, Orlath, Tarnovar, or the throne is the campaign's largest live decision from here forward. Every recipient is a different second half. Flag it prominently and do not rush them.
- **Standing moved this session:** Nothing moves, and it is worth saying that to yourself before the session and never to the players. No faction in the empire knows the party went down there, none would credit it if told, and the single most consequential thing any of them has done — a real oath, sworn aloud in the one place where sworn words carry — is witnessed by nobody who keeps a ledger. The only account that changed tonight is the one this document does not print: the thing behind the Seal heard the oath, and it remembers.

STAT BLOCKS

The Turned

Medium undead, neutral

Armor Class: 14 (grave-formal dress, hardened)

Hit Points: 52 (8d8 + 16)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	14 (+2)	15 (+2)	8 (-1)	12 (+1)	6 (-2)

Damage Resistances: necrotic, cold; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Condition Immunities: charmed, exhaustion, frightened, prone

Senses: blindsight 60 ft. (it has no eyes and does not need them), passive Perception 11

Languages: understands Old Imperial; cannot speak

Challenge: 3 (700 XP)

Averted. The Turned has no face. Its head is permanently averted from whatever it is nearest to, and it cannot be made to look by force, damage, or magic — only by being witnessed.

Only When Unobserved. The Turned can move and attack only while no creature is looking directly at it. A creature that spends its action watching one Turned (declared openly) freezes that Turned entirely for the duration. This is the encounter's core tension: attention costs actions, and there are more of them than there are of you.

Witnessed. If a creature holds its attention on a single Turned for one full round AND describes aloud what it sees — naming the Turned as a person who stood here and did nothing — the Turned turns to face the speaker, is laid to rest, and vanishes. No check. No damage. This is the intended solution and the module's whole thesis.

The Colder Room. Each Turned destroyed by damage rather than witnessed lowers the temperature of the Hall by a degree the party can feel, and the DM should say so, every time, without explanation.

ACTIONS

Unobserved Strike. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target that cannot currently see it. Hit: 14 (3d6 + 4) necrotic damage. The Turned cannot make this attack against a creature that is looking at it.

Turned Elder (six-character parties): as the Turned, but 68 hit points, and its Unobserved Strike deals an extra 4 (1d8) necrotic damage. It is the one at the front.

NPC NOTES — WHAT IS DOWN THERE

There are no living NPCs on the ceremonial floor, which is why this module has carried no profiles. But the Turned are addressable, players will try to address them, and a DM should not be improvising the answer.

- **The Turned, addressed.** They were people, and specifically they were the crowd — the witnesses who stood in this hall while the founding oath was broken, and turned their faces from it. They have no speech pattern because they have no mouths turned toward anyone; they answer in posture, and only to being seen. The Witnessed trait carries the mechanics. What it does not carry is the pacing: when the first Turned is genuinely witnessed and turns its head, that is the first time it has done so in two thousand years. Describe it slowly, once, and never again for the others — the second one should land as recognition, not as a repeated cutscene.
- **Turn Undead, and why it is worse than useless.** They are typed undead and Turn Undead works on them exactly as written — they flee, for the minute it lasts, and it accomplishes nothing whatsoever. They return unturned and unwitnessed, and the party has spent a slot and a minute teaching the room that the Church's instrument for the restless dead does not reach these ones. Let a devout character feel that land: these dead are not restless. They are waiting. What is owed them is the Vigil, and doctrine has never made the Vigil conditional on the dead having been good. A party that works this out here has already solved Session Eight.

DM Only: do not let a player talk a Turned into anything. They cannot be persuaded, bargained with, or absolved — there is nobody home to accept absolution. They can only be witnessed. The distinction is the whole architecture of the campaign in one encounter: the empire's problem was never that it did wrong, it was that it looked away, and looking is the only thing that undoes it.

LOOT AND FOUND REWARDS — SESSION SEVEN

Find	Value / Effect
The unused ceremonial vestments	Undecayed, cold-preserved, cut for a Drow of ordinary build. Not magical. Worth more than anything the party owns.
Nyreeza's working notes	Her measurements, the nine names, the four abandoned letters to her son, and a dynastic archive shelf-mark that leads to Vaskaren's order.
The frieze rubbing	The only above-ground record of the founding's true shape. Identifiable faces and house-sigils. A political weapon and a moral test.

Find	Value / Effect
The broken mason's chisel	Imperial make, guild-stamped, two centuries old. The physical thread to the scouring order.
Nyreeza's surveyor's chalk (second stub)	Mundane. Half-used. Free. Put it next to the first one.

REWARDS AND ADVANCEMENT

Coin: none, and nobody should expect any. Items and intangibles: the vestments nobody put on; Nyreeza's working notes, her nine names, and the dynastic shelf-mark that leads to Vaskaren's scouring order; the frieze rubbing, which is the most dangerous object in the empire; the broken chisel; a second stub of chalk. Two things matter more than any of them and belong in the Branch Ledger tonight, in the players' own words: the Seal-oath, verbatim, and each character's unkept promise from the Long Approach. XP for tables using it: the Turned are worth 700 apiece, which is nowhere near the pace of 7th level, and that is deliberate — the Undercourt pays in something else. Award the level at the milestone regardless of the tally. Milestone: 7th level in the Witness Hall, under the faces.

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"They are not fleeing. They are not screaming. They have decided, together and without a word, to see nothing at all."